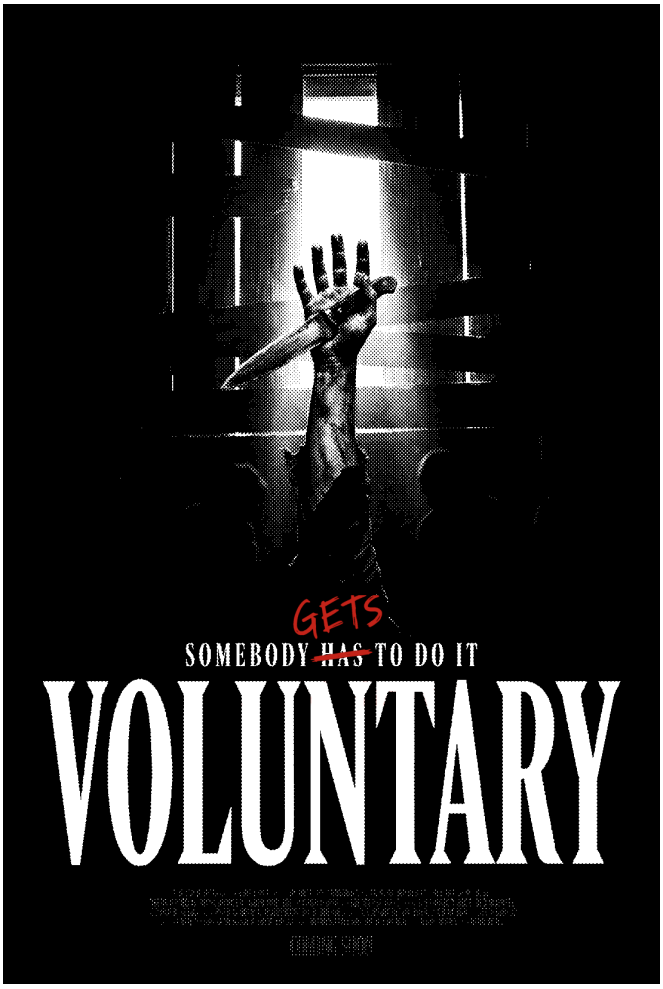


VOLUNTARY

Punchy, tense comedy. Approx. 4 min.

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CAST OF 5.
TERRY - The Volunteer. Played by Josh. Reads as the most normal,
most reasonable person in the room. That is the whole trick.
DEAN - The Bitten. The emotional anchor. Has to spiral and oversell
without ever winking.
CRISTIAN - Missing teeth. Practical, unbothered, wrong. Already
survived something.
NYLA - The nurse. Patches everyone up. The one who tries to fix
things.
CATHY - The one who says the quiet part, at volume.

ONE LOCATION. Boarded-up living room. Lantern light.
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INT. BOARDED-UP LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Windows blocked with scrap lumber. A camping lantern and a work light do all the work. Canned food stacked where a TV used to be.

CLOSE ON A MOUTH.

CRISTIAN's. Open. Breathing shallow. Two teeth gone, the gap dark and real.

A hand tilts his chin toward the lantern to see better.

WIDEN. CRISTIAN sits on the coffee table, shirt off, bloody. NYLA works on a gash in his shoulder with a rag and a bowl of water gone pink. It's quiet. It's tender. They have done this before.

CATHY watches from the doorway, arms crossed, listening to the room rather than looking at it.

NYLA
Hold still.

CRISTIAN
I am still.

NYLA
You're talking.

CRISTIAN
That's not moving.

NYLA
Talking is moving.

CRISTIAN
Since when.

CATHY
Shh.

They stop. She is not looking at them. She is listening at the boards.

Nobody moves.

The front door BANGS open.

DEAN falls through it, wild, clutching his left forearm. Blood on his sleeve.

DEAN
I got bit. I got bit, I got bit --

Everyone is up. NYLA drops the rag.

NYLA
Where --

DEAN
Tie me up. Right now. Tie me up.

CATHY
Dean.

DEAN
TIE ME UP.

NYLA moves toward his arm.

NYLA
Let me see it. Let me just look at it, maybe we can --

DEAN
(pulling away)
No. There's no time. I can already feel it.

TERRY comes in from the hallway. Takes in the room. Calm.

TERRY
What happened.

DEAN
I got bit.

Beat. TERRY looks at the arm. At DEAN. Something crosses his face and leaves.

TERRY
Okay.

DEAN
Tie me up.

CRISTIAN
We don't have to --

DEAN
Behind. Behind my back. Do it behind my back.

They sit him in a hard chair. NYLA and CATHY work the rope around his chest and the chair back. CRISTIAN takes the wrists, behind.

DEAN (CONT'D)
Tighter.

CRISTIAN
It's tight.

DEAN
Tighter, Cristian.

CRISTIAN
(not adjusting anything)
Okay.

They step back. He's tied. The room settles into something awful.

DEAN (CONT'D)
You have to kill me.

NYLA
Dean.

DEAN
It's only a matter of time. You know it is. You have to do it before I turn, or I take all of you with me.

Silence. It's true and everyone knows it's true.

CATHY looks at the floor. NYLA is crying and trying not to. CRISTIAN stares at the far wall.

TERRY
Okay.

Everyone turns.

TERRY (CONT'D)
I'll do it.

A long, uneasy, grateful beat. NYLA puts a hand on his arm.

NYLA
Terry --

TERRY
It's fine.

CATHY
That's -- thank you. Genuinely.

TERRY
No, you don't understand.

He looks at each of them.

TERRY (CONT'D)
It has to be me.

He is looking straight into DEAN when he says it.

NYLA
...Okay. Thank you. But why?

TERRY
Well. I mean.

(beat)

You guys know.

NYLA
Know what.

TERRY
Because I actually hate him.

The room stops.

CATHY
Wait, WHAT?

NYLA
What?

CRISTIAN
(genuinely, to himself)
Huh.

DEAN
Just do it, I don't care, just do it, I can feel it coming --

(stopping)

Wait. What do you mean you hate me?

TERRY
Come on.

DEAN
What do you MEAN --

TERRY
(to the room, reasonable)
Don't act like you don't know. I clearly hate him. I'm going to enjoy this. That's why it has to be me.

NYLA
That is a horrible thing to say to him right now.

TERRY
Is it?

TERRY (CONT'D)
Would you rather get killed by somebody who's going to enjoy it? Or by a friend who's shaking, who's crying, who's never done it, and it takes four tries?

Silence. It is, unfortunately, a good point.

CRISTIAN
(matter of fact)
He's not wrong.

NYLA
Cristian.

CRISTIAN
He's not!

DEAN
(deflating)
...No. I guess not.

(beat)

Just do it. I can feel it coming on.

TERRY takes the knife out. Turns it over. Wipes it down the leg of his jeans, which makes it worse, not better. Seems satisfied.

Then he crosses to DEAN and goes straight for the throat. No hesitation at all. He is a foot away before anybody says anything.

DEAN (CONT'D)
Wait wait wait wait.

TERRY stops, patient.

DEAN (CONT'D)
This is really weird. This is really, really weird.

(to the room)

Is this weird? Guys. Is this weird?

CATHY
Yeah, it's really weird.

NYLA
It's weird, Terry.

TERRY
I know.

(beat)

But it's not weird for me.

NYLA
What does that mean?

TERRY
This is therapeutic. This is a genuinely good thing that's happening.

DEAN starts to go.

DEAN
Oh my God. Oh my God, I can feel it, okay, just do it, just do it --

(gaining momentum)

I love you guys. I love you guys so much. You are the best thing that ever happened to me. More than my family. I mean that. I'd be nothing without you, I'd be NOTHING --

His voice catches. Thickens. Turns into a low, wet, gravelly rattle in the throat.

NYLA gasps. CATHY steps back.

DEAN (CONT'D)
(through it)
-- it's happening, it's happening, do it --

He does not stop. He keeps finding more. Every few words he checks the room to see whether anybody is going to get up.

Nobody gets up.

TERRY rolls his eyes. Not cruelly. The way you do when someone will not get to the point.

He raises the knife to DEAN's neck.

And DEAN, lost in the performance, straining against the rope, WORKS HIS LEFT ARM LOOSE without noticing, and throws it up in a gesture.

The forearm passes right in front of TERRY's face.

TERRY stops.

The blood on it has smeared. Dragged sideways across the skin. Too much of it, and wrong, and wipeable.

TERRY lowers the knife an inch.

DEAN (CONT'D)
(eyes shut, still going)
-- tell my sister I --

TERRY catches the wrist. Turns the forearm into the light. Looks at the bite.

Then, slowly, he lifts DEAN's own arm up to DEAN's own mouth.

The teeth line up.

DEAN's eyes open.

They make eye contact.

A silence with a floor falling out of it.

TERRY
No.

DEAN
...

CATHY
What. What is it.

TERRY does not answer her. He lifts DEAN's arm back up to DEAN's mouth and holds it there, so the whole room can see the marks sit into the gaps exactly.

He holds it. Nobody needs it explained.

NYLA
...Oh my God.

TERRY
(to DEAN, quiet)
You were really gonna let me do it.

And DEAN, busted, does not apologize. DEAN detonates.

DEAN
I KNEW IT.

TERRY
Oh, you --

DEAN
I KNEW IT! I KNEW you'd do it! I KNEW you would kill me!

TERRY
(to the room, arms out, vindicated)
Are you guys seeing this?

DEAN
I set that up, and you --

TERRY
Are you SEEING this. THIS is why I should kill him. It is ALWAYS this. It is always this exact thing.

DEAN
Yeah! And now they know! Now they all know you'd kill me!

(to the room)

GREAT job, everybody. Great job.

TERRY
He's always pulling this shit.

Everyone looks at DEAN. DEAN looks like a man who has been caught pulling this shit before.

Then CATHY turns on both of them.

CATHY
What the f--- is wrong with you two?

TERRY
With ME?

CATHY
(to DEAN)
You were going to let him put a knife in your neck to WIN AN ARGUMENT?

DEAN
To prove a point.

CATHY
(to TERRY)
And YOU. You were going to DO IT.

TERRY
Oh, I'm the bad guy now. Because I was going to "enjoy" saving all of our lives.

(beat)

Wow.

NYLA
Terry, you were standing over him like a man cutting a cake.

TERRY
Because I was FOCUSED.

CRISTIAN
(quietly, to nobody)
I'm still going to need the teeth.

Everyone is yelling. Nobody is the hero. DEAN is still tied to the chair, arguing at full volume, one arm free.

Outside, something drags past the boarded window.

Nobody notices.

CUT TO BLACK.

END